

Episode 147: Long Ago... 86 1995 Part 6 Somewhat Heavy April and May

Every year, my biggest concern in December, or rather agony, is actually New Year's cards.

Honestly, New Year's cards - please, no more! I think. Because I have to think about design right in the middle of year-end rush and such, and that's extremely difficult. "Then just stop! Quit doing them!" people say, and actually I think "should I quit?" too, but still, since I'm the eldest son, I need to send them to relatives, and there are old acquaintances and friends connected only through New Year's card exchanges. Plus, every year Web Anime Style here sends me that annual New Year's card project proposal (laugh).

"Then just buy ready-made designs and send those," people say, but that also seems somehow bland. Well, it's not like I can write or draw anything particularly impressive. I'm just stubborn about wanting to make my own design no matter how terrible it is.

That's why it's quite difficult (bitter laugh).

Actually, next year I discovered I'm a zodiac year man! Wow, the zodiac has finally cycled four times (sweat). My goodness. "Then let's work hard and make something amazing!" ...But you see, again, this is impossible.

Such is me caught in the New Year's card spiral this December.

Anyway.

After returning from the mysterious "2-night, 3-day Seoul kidnapping & hospitality tour," we immediately faced the sarin incident, followed by the shooting incident targeting National Police Agency Commissioner-General Kunitatsu, and society was

wrapped in heavy atmosphere during spring 1995. I entered April feeling quite unsettled by these two major incidents.

"Maybe it'll be quiet for a while?" I thought, but the script for the next theatrical work was properly waiting for me. Script: Koyama Takao, Art Setting: Kubota Tadao, Art Director: Higashi Jun'ichi, Animation Director: Yamamuro Tadayoshi, Supervisor: Yamauchi Shigeyasu, Director: Hashimoto Mitsuo. Theatrical *Dragon Ball Z: Dragon Fist Explosion!! If Goku Won't Do It, Who Will?* This was my 6th theatrical *Dragon Ball Z*.

One day, a mysterious old man appears before Great Saiyaman (Gohan and Videl), pleading to release a hero sealed in a music box. The hero Tapion appears when the seal is broken by calling the Dragon. Trunks adores Tapion like a brother, but Tapion's expression hardens and he pushes Trunks away. Actually, the monster Hirudegarn is sealed within Tapion's body, and with Tapion's revival, Hirudegarn's seal is also broken and he revives. Then the death battle between Hirudegarn and Goku's group begins... Such was the story.

In theatrical *Dragon Ball Z* films, series creator Toriyama Akira-san usually wasn't involved much in the stories themselves, but he would draw original concepts for guest characters appearing in the films if requested. This time, seeing the rough drawing of hero Tapion's character concept sent by Toriyama-san, we staff all said the same thing in unison: "Is this going to be okay? (sweat)" The rough drawing sent looked exactly like Chrono, a key character from the Super Famicom game "Chrono Trigger" that had been released just about a month earlier.

This "Chrono Trigger" was a game where Toriyama-san handled character design, and it had quite a reputation even before release. "Probably when Toriyama-san draws now, everyone ends up looking similar in this direction," we thought. Still, we couldn't exactly reject Toriyama-san's work, so Yamamuro-san and director Hashimoto-kun consulted and gradually tweaked details to make the character. Then it came to me. Time to decide colours.

Now, what to do?

How much can you change something that already looks similar at the line art level through colour? If it were me now, I might have thought about it more and established some strategy, but at that time, I was completely influenced by "Chrono." The colours of this "Chrono" were really good. They perfectly hit my sweet spot at the time. And above all, this Tapion's positioning in the story and that colour balance strangely matched. If I wanted to change the impression through colour, I should have done the exact opposite of "Chrono's" colouring scheme and adjusted from there, but story-wise, a bright-coloured Tapion was impossible, and most importantly, myself, Hashimoto-kun, and Yamamuro-san were all somehow imagining red hair. So with red hair and subdued blue-tinted clothes... no matter how we changed small parts, it would inevitably become "Chrono."

"This is definitely problematic!" said producer Morishita-san. Well, yes. Exactly right. We understood that. What should we do? But well, it can't be helped - that's the direction it went, and I think we ultimately removed the bandana he originally had to show the shaved head part, modified hair from red to orange-tinted vermillion, further adjusted clothing shape, moved the colour used for clothes to a long scarf, and changed the clothes themselves to lighter brown. This gave us somewhat of a "different thing" feeling.

Now, we somehow found a compromise for Tapion, but actually Hirudegarn too. Hirudegarn first appears as upper and lower body, which was still okay, but when combined into complete form, it started looking like Cell. But well, this was similar-or-not within the same *Dragon Ball Z*, so "it's not on screen very long anyway (laugh)" and we somehow cleared it.

But honestly, as a *Dragon Ball Z* work, it was already at its limit. Character design and story - we were simply out of material. The TV and theatrical series that had continued endlessly up to this point - their former charm had become quite questionable.

And in such circumstances, that day finally came. The end of *Dragon Ball's* serialisation in Weekly Shonen Jump was decided.

(10.12.07)